Who is Katon Moyong? Why Arunachal activist's fiery speech against Siang dam is going viral

Arunachal Pradesh activist Katon Moyong has gained national attention after his speech opposing the proposed Siang mega dam went viral. Here is who he is, what the Adi community is demanding and why the hydropower project has become controversial.

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New Delhi: A speech by Arunachal Pradesh activist Katon Moyong, also referred to as Moyong Katon, has drawn widespread attention on social media. The environmental engineer, popularly known as 'Abor Man', has openly challenged the state government over its proposed mega dam on the Siang River. His remarks about the rights of indigenous communities, national security and the government's approach to development have brought a long-running dispute into the national spotlight.

Speaking at a press conference in Itanagar on November 5, Moyong rejected further talks on the proposed Siang Upper Multipurpose Project (SUMP). Addressing Chief Minister Pema Khandu, he said, "We have been saying no to the Siang dam for 47 years." He argued that successive governments had ignored the concerns of people living along the river and questioned the use of national security to justify the project.

First time after being detained in New Delhi , Moyong Katon gave an impeccable press briefing to Eastern Journal, a local media .

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November 5, 2026

Who is Katon Moyong?

Katon Moyong is an environmental engineer and activist from Arunachal Pradesh's Adi community. He represents the youth wing of the Siang Indigenous Farmers Forum (SIFF), which opposes the proposed dam.

According to ThePrint, Moyong has visited 56 villages to explain the project's possible impact on local communities. He has collected signatures and documented opposition to the dam. His campaign gained attention through public speeches and social media videos during 2024 and 2025.

Who are the Adi people of Arunachal Pradesh?

The Adi are one of the major indigenous tribal communities of Arunachal Pradesh, living mainly along the Siang River in the eastern Himalayas. Their history stretches back centuries, long before India's independence, with oral traditions tracing their ancestry to Abo Tani, a central figure in the history and beliefs of several tribes in the region. Historical accounts suggest that Adi ancestors migrated from areas to the north, possibly Tibet, although their exact origins remain uncertain. The community includes several groups, such as the Minyong, Padam, Pasi and Milang. Traditionally, the Adi have depended on farming, forests and rivers for their livelihoods. They follow a system of village self-governance called the Kebang, where community matters and disputes are discussed. Their cultural practices include the Donyi-Polo tradition, associated with the Sun and Moon, and festivals such as Solung. For many Adi families, the Siang River is deeply connected to their ancestry, traditions and identity.

What is Katon Moyong demanding?

Moyong wants the government to stop the preliminary surveys for the proposed dam and obtain approval from all 60 concerned village councils before discussing the project.

He has demanded the release of detained anti-dam protesters and questioned the deployment of security forces in the Siang region.

His message to the government is clear. He opposes a mega dam on the main Siang River, though he has expressed support for smaller hydropower projects elsewhere.

What is the Siang dam controversy?

The proposed Siang Upper Multipurpose Project is a major hydropower and water management project in Arunachal Pradesh, with a planned capacity of around 11,000 MW.

The Centre and state government argue that the project could help India manage the potential impact of China's massive hydropower development on the Yarlung Tsangpo River in Tibet, which flows into India as the Siang.

Opposing communities fear that the project could submerge agricultural land, displace villages, and damage their cultural connection with the river. The Adi community considers the Siang an important part of its identity and ancestral heritage.

Why is Moyong's speech going viral?

One of the most widely discussed parts of his speech concerns his rejection of the government's national security argument.

"India was born in 1947 and China in 1949. We have been living here much before that," Moyong said, referring to the indigenous community's long history in the region.

His direct criticism of political leaders and warning that the Adi people would fiercely resist the dam have attracted attention beyond Arunachal Pradesh. His remarks came amid protests, arrests and growing public debate over the project.

Chief Minister Pema Khandu has defended the project's strategic significance while acknowledging that local communities must be consulted.